CENTRAL ASIA

Central Asia faces declining water inflows and glacier mass, WMO study finds

The World Meteorological Organization has reported declining water inflows and glacier mass across Central Asia, with the Amu Darya and Syr Darya basin among the region's most affected areas.

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Water inflows to reservoirs in Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, Kyrgyzstan and Afghanistan have declined significantly, while Central Asian glaciers are losing more ice than they accumulate, according to researchers from the World Meteorological Organization.

The researchers compared indicators from the past five years with data from 1991–2020. Their assessment placed Central Asia among the regions where river flows were below or significantly below normal. The situation is particularly concerning in the Aral Sea basin, which includes the Amu Darya and Syr Darya

river systems. Reduced water inflows are affecting reservoirs across several countries in the region.

Glacier conditions are also raising concern. Mountain glaciers across Central Asia are losing more ice than they are accumulating, with the region ranked among the three areas that have experienced the greatest glacier mass losses in the history of observations.

More than half of the flow in Central Asian river basins originates from snow and glaciers, making changes in mountain ice reserves particularly important for the region's water supply.

Globally, glaciers lost an estimated 1,400 gigatons of water between 2023 and 2025, according to the assessment.

Over the past five years, mountain glaciers have lost 6.2% of their ice mass above sea level, highlighting the continued decline in the region's long-term water reserves.

The findings come amid other environmental pressures in Central Asia. Kyrgyzstan was previously reported to have lost nearly 90% of its forests over a 50-year period, with the sharp decline in forest cover linked to worsening problems related to floods, landslides and water resources.

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